

MOUNTAINS, LAKES, AND PRAIRIES

North America

North America is the third largest continent. Geographically, it is also considered to include Greenland. Most of the continent lies on a single tectonic plate, with small parts of Mexico and California lying on the Pacific Plate to the west, which borders the North American Plate along the infamous San Andreas Fault.

Unusually, North America has a vast and ancient lowland heart, almost completely surrounded by younger belts of fold mountains thrown up by continental collisions in the past. This lowland heart, with its Great Plains and Great Lakes, is drained almost entirely by one of the world's great river systems, the Mississippi—Missouri, which channels water south into the Gulf of Mexico. The Appalachian range in the east

is relatively old and has been worn low over time. But the Western Cordillera, which includes the Alaska, Cascade, and Coast ranges and the inland Rocky Mountains, running down the western limb of the continent, is geologically young and still high—so high that these mountains block the flow of moist air from the Pacific. This gives much of the interior a markedly continental climate with bitter winters and hot summers punctuated by tornadoes, and in the south the lack of rain creates large deserts. Only to the north are there no mountains, and the expanse of the Canadian Shield stretches north into the bitter wastes of the Arctic.

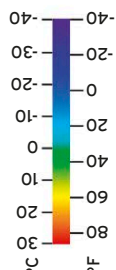
KEY DATA

- Highest point** Denali, Alaska: 20,308 ft (6,190 m)
- Lowest point** Death Valley, California: -282 ft (-86 m)
- Hottest record** Death Valley, California: 134°F (57°C)
- Colest record** Northice, Greenland: -87°F (-66°C)

CLIMATE

Most of North America lies in the temperate zone, with a subtropical south and an Arctic north. The coasts are moist, but the interior is drier.

AVERAGE TEMPERATURE



AVERAGE RAINFALL

